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‘Not on our watch’: Warrenton Town Council reverses course on license plate readers

Grace Schumacher | FauquierNow
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Ward 5 Councilmember Eric Gagnon and At-Large Councilmember David McGuire introduced a motion to suspend all current and future discussions on implementing automatic license plate reader technology in the town of Warrenton during the council's Oct. 14 meeting.

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The Warrenton Town Council voted 5-1 Tuesday afternoon to permanently suspend all future discussion and consideration of the Warrenton Police Department's proposal to install automated license plate reader cameras at the town's main entrances.

The council also voted to reallocate the funds set aside for the project.

Police Chief Timothy Carter presented the plan in September, proposing the use of Flock Safety's "Falcon" camera system as "a force multiplier" to help solve crimes locally and coordinate with law enforcement agencies statewide. The cameras capture still images of vehicle rear plates along with make, model, color and distinguishing features.

The council did not vote on the matter during its Sept. 9 meeting. Instead, a "head nod discussion" directed the Public Safety Committee and Carter to hold discussions with the community and return with a report within two months.

At-Large Councilmember David McGuire introduced the motion to end consideration of the proposal, stating, "We're saying we, the councilmembers, don't even want to consider this."

At At-Large Councilmember Paul Mooney's request, Carter addressed the council.

"The Warrenton Police Department is not married to this technology. It is a tool that we are presenting for potential use in the town. If the Town Council or the community decides that they don't want it, that's fine," he said. "In my professional opinion, it would be good to at least put the information out there, what it is and what it's not, instead of letting people go with whatever they've heard and to get feedback from the community."

He stated that he would defer to the council, adding, “I would not stand in the way or object. I’m just telling you that I believe that this is a tool that we could use in this town.”

McGuire argued for completely removing the proposal.

“It’s going to cost us time and money. We’re going to be wedded to this project, and it’s also an invasion of privacy,” he said. “If you look at all the letters to the editor and everything else, nobody is for this. That’s why I’m saying this is a waste of our time and effort, and the citizens do not want it.”

Ward 5 Councilmember Eric Gagnon supported the motion.

“I’ve had a fair number of people coming up to me saying, ‘What are you guys thinking?’ The community does not want these license plate reader cameras,” he said.

Gagnon said his own research showed other municipalities had experienced problems with the technology and privacy concerns.

Ward 3 Councilmember Larry Kovalik said he recalled from the September proposal that “a tremendous amount of vehicles were being monitored with very little return.”

Gagnon said the negative feedback was substantial.

“I don’t think that it’s appropriate for us [to consider] when we are already starting to get overwhelmingly negative feedback,” he said. “At some point we’ve got to exercise some oversight on mass surveillance technologies like this, and say, ‘Not on our watch. This council is not going to get involved in this kind of stuff.’”

In the roll-call vote, five councilmembers supported the motion. Ward 1 Councilmember Roy Francis cast the lone “nay” vote.

Ward 4 Councilmember Michele O’Halloran, who supported the potential implementation of the technology in future discussions, was absent and did not vote.

The Warrenton Police Department had scheduled two public meetings to gather feedback on Oct. 21 and Nov. 6. Both will be canceled.

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